

“Davis and other leaders of the South ... have **made a nation.**”

W. E. GLADSTONE, BRITISH CHANCELLOR OF THE EXCHEQUER, OCTOBER 1862

Arms supplies to the South

Real tensions would persist, especially with Confederate agents buying ships in Britain, and then arming and converting them into commerce raiders—ships that were used to disrupt or destroy the enemy’s merchant shipping— in other ports. However, British leaders gradually responded to Northern complaints about this issue, and the adept American minister to London, Charles Francis Adams, ably served the administration’s interests. Matters came to a head when the British government finally moved to prevent the Confederacy from acquiring the “Laird Rams,” two ironclad warships being built in Liverpool, England, that could have wreaked havoc on the Union blockade patrols. The Union government went as far as to threaten war with Britain over the two ships, and the British relented, buying the ships for their own navy in the fall of 1863.

The South found that if it wished to win its independence, it would have to rely on its own efforts and exertions. It could not hope for the same sort of assistance that the United States had received from France during the American Revolution.

When Charles Francis Adams was presented to Queen Victoria after the *Trent* Affair, he sought to defuse tensions by appearing in stockings and lace, as opposed to the customary black republican broadcloth used by most American ministers.